A contributor's guide

What every page is for, what you can do on it, and the tools built in to help you check a house.

As it stood on 14 October 2026. The current version is always at https://nottinghamparkhouses.com/guide

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What you can and cannot add

> **The record holds people who have died, and everything in it is public.** That is the whole of the rule. Everything below follows from it, and it matters more than anything else in this guide.

Do not add a living person. Adding somebody new needs a first name, a surname, a year of birth and a place of birth — and **a year of death if they were born in the last hundred years**. The form will not accept them without it, and that is deliberate: the law protects the living, and a public record of named people is exactly the thing it protects them from. If you cannot show somebody has died, they do not go in.

Do not record who lives in a house now. Present-day owners and occupiers are not part of the record. Where a house carries a name its current owner uses, that is a name on a house — the name goes in, the householder does not.

Do not write about a living person anywhere else either. Not in a house's history, not in a discussion thread, not under a photograph, not in a research question. A living person's name, address, job, health, family, movements or anything else about them does not go into a public record, however harmless it looks and however freely they told you.

Photograph the building, from the pavement. Not people, not through windows, not over walls, not inside anybody's house. If somebody walks into the shot, take another one.

Living people do belong in two places, and only these. You may name yourself — your own account, your own contributions, your own posts on the Discussion board. And you may name somebody as the *source* of something, with their permission: "told to me by the owner of number 14" needs no name at all and is usually better.

The census is different. Everybody in the 1841 to 1921 censuses and the 1939 Register has been dead a long time, and the records are published by The National Archives precisely so they can be read. They come in as whole documents and none of this applies to them.

If you are not sure, ask first. Put it on the Discussion board and leave it out of the record until somebody answers. Something left out can be added next week. Something published about a living person cannot be unpublished.

If you think something here should not be here — about you or about anybody else — say so on **the form** and it will be taken out while it is looked at. You do not have to explain why, and you do not need an account to ask. It raises a notice the moment it arrives, so it is seen the same day rather than whenever somebody next looks.

If you have a query about a house, the place for it is the Discussion board — not a guess typed into the record. See section 5.

What the record is

This record covers four hundred houses on The Park Estate and the people who lived in them from the 1840s to the 1939 Register. Much of it is already here; a good deal is not, and some of what is here is wrong. Almost everything a contributor does is one of three things: putting a person in the right house, making sure one person is not recorded as two, or attaching an outside source to somebody. The pages below are organised around those jobs.

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1. How the site is arranged

Every page carries the same bar. The row of links across it never changes and is public. What appears to the right of it depends on who is signed in.

Menu	Who sees it	What is in it
The public row	Everybody	Map, People, Notable, Architects, Census, Insights, Occupations, Origins, Estate history, Archive, Walk it, Who moved, Dashboard
Research	Contributors and admins	The working pages — the backlogs, the review queues, Needs work, Discussion and Open questions
Mine	Anyone signed in	Your part in it, My watchlist, My contributions
Admin	Admins only	Admin tools, Users, Birthplaces, Activity and alerts, Who is reading it, Photos from the walk

If you are not signed in you will see **Join the record** instead. An admin approves the account and sets it to contributor; until then you can read everything but change nothing.

Two things used to sit on the public row and have moved. **Family trees** is off it until it works properly. **Open questions** is in the Research menu now: it is a list of jobs, not a thing to read.

2. The pages everyone can see

Page	What it is for
Map (`/`)	The estate itself. Click a house for its details, history, architectural description, photographs, residents and a timeline that draws together when it was built, who lived there, each census, and every volume of Wright's Directory that prints somebody at it. Two buttons sit under the title: **Street View**, and **Ask about this house**, which opens a discussion thread with the house already filled in.
People (`/people`)	Every person, searchable. Open a profile for their censuses, occupations, family links, sources and photograph. Contributors can edit here, add a person, and merge two records into one.
Notable (`/significant`)	Residents chosen for the offices they held, the honours they received, or the lives they led, with a person of the week. Contributors can propose and remove people.
Architects (`/architects`)	Firms and individuals and the buildings attributed to them.
Census (`/census`)	Coverage year by year: which houses have a record, which were unoccupied, which have nothing.
Insights (`/stats`)	Statistics across the estate — building dates, occupations, streets, architects.
Occupations (`/trades`)	What people did, gathered into trades.
Origins (`/origins`)	Where residents were born, mapped.
Estate history (`/history`)	How the ground came to be built on, from the castle rock to the sale in the 1930s.
Archive (`/archive`)	Maps, plans, deeds and photographs of the estate as a whole, rather than of one house.
Walk it (`/walk`)	The record taken out of doors — see section 3.
Who moved (`/moves`)	People traced from one house on the estate to another, drawn on the map. Somebody who appears at two addresses in two censuses is one of the strongest things the record holds, and it is easy to miss one house at a time.
Dashboard (`/dashboard`)	The state of the record: what is counted, what is outstanding.

3. Walk it — the record on foot

The Park Walk (`/walk`) is for the part of the research that cannot be done sitting down. It knows where you are, and gives you the houses nearest to you first.

It asks two things before it starts: **how long have you got** — fifteen minutes, half an hour, an hour, or no limit — and **what are you in the mood for**. The moods are:

Mood	What it puts in front of you
A bit of everything	A mixture, nearest first
Fix an unnumbered run	Terraces where the record cannot say which house is which
Be useful	Whatever is most wanted nearby
Who lived here	Questions about residents

Mood	What it puts in front of you
Who built it	Questions about builders and architects
What is gone	Houses that are no longer there
Full houses	Houses with a crowded census year to check
Take some photographs	Houses with no photograph at all
Bring them up to date	Houses whose only pictures came with the original import
Read the post boxes	Post boxes, and whose reign is on the cypher

Three things worth knowing:

- **The enumerator's round** walks a census in the order the enumerator walked it, so you get the feel of the round rather than a scatter of houses. It gives you a couple of houses before the long stretch and a couple after, with the explanation up front.
- **Post boxes** are recorded with the cypher on the door — VR, EVIIR, GR, GVIR, EIIR and the rest — which dates the box to a reign.
- **Photographs** taken on the walk are marked as having come from the walk, and go to an admin to look at. Nothing you send is ever deleted; the worst that happens is the house goes back on the list for a better one.

Your phone will not lock itself while the walk is open, the way a recipe app keeps the screen on. Add the site to your home screen and the walk works as an app.

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4. The Research menu: the working pages

These are the contributor's pages. Each takes one kind of problem and gathers the whole backlog of it in one place, so it can be worked down rather than stumbled upon a house at a time.

Where to start

Page	What it does
Needs work (`/needs-work`)	Jobs somebody could finish in an evening, in six groups: notable people with no account written; people with a Wikipedia article and nothing in the record; a title and nothing else; houses nobody has ever been found living in; houses with nothing for 1939; houses with no history written; households with no house; and open questions about where a house is. Each job says what is missing and what would finish it.
Discussion (`/discussion`)	The place to ask — see section 5.
Open questions (`/research`)	The things that cannot be read out of a document — see section 6.

Picking something up. On Needs work you can say *I'm looking into this*, which puts your name against the job so two people do not do the same search. It is not a lock: anyone can still work on it, and it can be handed back. The same applies to a property, a person, a household or a question.

Getting people into the right house

Page	What it does
Unfiled records (`/unfiled`)	Census records attached to no property, grouped by the address they carry rather than listed one by one — most of the backlog is a few addresses repeated many times, so a whole group can be settled at once. You can file a group to a house, relabel its address, or set it aside when it needs a source the record does not have.
Unresolved census (`/census/unresolved`)	People whose address could not be matched to a Park property at all.
Split a house's census (`/reassign`)	Everyone recorded at one address in one year, grouped into households by the order they were entered, each Head starting a new one. Put the right property number beside each household. **This is the page that moves a record between houses.**
Crowded houses (`/crowding`)	Houses holding an improbable number of people in one year — usually several households filed against one address. Distinct surnames is the stronger tell.

Making sure one person is one person

Page	What it does
Duplicate people (`/duplicates`)	Two records sharing a surname and forename, born within two years of each other. The census spreadsheets were loaded separately and name people differently, which is where most of these come from. Merge, or dismiss the pair.
Names to check (`/name-review`)	Names that do not look right — a question mark where a forename should be, a bare initial, a spelling one slip from an ordinary name.
Forename sex (`/name-sex`)	One click per name rather than per person: setting Mary covers every Mary in the record. Commonest names first, so the early clicks do the most work.

Attaching outside evidence

Page	What it does
Directories by street (`/directory-check`)	Every householder Wright's Directory prints on a Park street, put against a house wherever its own number or house name says which, and set beside who the census has there. Mark a line right, link it to a person, move it to another house, dismiss it, or record that you looked for somebody in a census year and they were not there.
Directories by surname (`/directory-people`)	The same evidence gathered by surname instead of by street, so one family can be followed across the whole estate.
Architects & lace makers (`/directory-watch`)	Architects and lace makers followed through their own directory entries, including a few who do not live here yet — it is how you catch one moving in.
Gazette by person (`/gazette-review`)	Official notices gathered under the person they were found for. A search cannot tell one John Smith from another, so open the notice and say whether it is your resident.

Page	What it does
Wikidata review (`/wikidata-review`)	Every resident without a Wikipedia link checked against the Wikidata pool in one pass. A shared name is not an identification.
Medal cards (`/medals-review`)	First World War medal index cards from The National Archives, matched against people here. A card gives no birth year, so the match needs judging.

Getting the houses themselves right

Page	What it does
Positions vs OpenStreetMap (`/osm`)	Many positions here were reasoned rather than surveyed — placed from the enumerator's round. This compares them with real building outlines and reports the ones that are simply wrong.
Listed buildings (`/listings`)	Every house beside the National Heritage List entries within 40 metres of it, so the estate can be settled in one pass. Each links to its Historic England record.
Dougal's map (`/map-review`)	House names on the Park Map that match no property, and the architect each house's fill colour points to. Neither is evidence — the page judges nothing and leaves the deciding to you.

Tidying up

Page	What it does
Occupations to sort (`/occupations`)	Occupations the record could not put into a trade. Most are obvious to a person and impossible to a rule. The wording is never changed — a compound occupation is grouped on the trade it begins with and the words stay as the enumerator wrote them.

Keeping track

- **The working list** (`/tasks`) — everything outstanding, broken into pieces small enough to finish. Most are one or two clicks; those marked *research* need a source the record has not got, and those marked *ongoing* are worked down rather than completed.
- **Your part in it** (`/me`) — what you have added, what it has earned you, and what you would like to be told about. See section 7.
- **My watchlist** (`/watchlist`) — star any house on the map and it collects here.
- **My contributions** (`/my-contributions`) — what you have changed.

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5. Discussion — where a query about a house goes

If you have a question about a house, ask it on the Discussion board. It is for the things that are not research questions yet: a memory, a photograph of a deed, a suspicion about a wall, a name somebody's grandmother used. Ask, and other people chip in.

The quickest way in: open the house on the map and press "Ask about this house". The board opens with that house already filled in — you only have to type the question.

- **A thread can be tied** to a house, a person, or an open question. Tying it to a house is what makes it show up for anybody working on that house.
- **Tie it to an open question and settling the thread answers the question.** Press **Settle** and what you write becomes the answer on the question itself, so the conclusion is not left buried in a conversation.
- **Anyone can read it.** To post, join the record or sign in.
- **Replies can be voted up**, so the useful answer rises.
- **Without an account**, the form takes a question just as well, and somebody writes back.

What belongs here rather than in the record: anything you are not sure of. A guess typed into a house's history is indistinguishable from a fact a week later. A guess in a thread is a question somebody can answer.

What belongs in **Open questions** instead: a specific thing that a specific source would settle — a rate book, a deed, a gatepost. Discussion is for working out what the question is; Open questions is for the search once you know.

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6. Open questions — the research section

Some of what is missing cannot be read out of a document. It needs somebody to walk down the road and look at a gatepost, to remember what a house was called, or to open a rate book in the Archives. Those go here, each with the evidence already gathered and what would settle it, so no one repeats the search.

- **Add a question** — anyone with contributor rights can open one, against a house or on its own.
- **I'm looking into this** — claims it, so two people do not do the same search. The claim can be handed back.
- **Record what you found** — writes the answer onto the question and closes it. An answer is kept even when it is negative: knowing a name is *not* in a rate book saves the next person the trip.
- **Reopen it** — an answered question can be reopened when something new turns up.
- **Remove** — admins only.

Questions marked as answerable **on foot** are the ones the Walk picks up, so a question you write carefully may be answered by somebody standing in front of the house a fortnight later.

Questions are also where corrections live. If the record says one thing and a source says another, the question holds both, with the reasoning — which is what stops the same wrong date or wrong house being entered again from whatever source first supplied it.

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7. Your part in it — badges and being told things

Your part in it (`/me`) gathers what you have done, what it has earned, and what you want to hear about.

Badges are counted from the record itself rather than awarded, and most have three tiers — bronze, silver, gold:

Badge	For
First light	Your first change to the record
Photographer	Houses you have photographed from the pavement
On the ground	Questions you answered standing in front of the house
Post box hunter	Post boxes you found and read the cypher on
Filing clerk	Households you found a house for
Person updater	People whose record you have improved
House historian	Houses you have written up
Good question	Discussions you have opened
Chipped in	Replies you have written to somebody else
Settled it	Questions answered because of a discussion you opened
Picked it up	Jobs from the Needs work list you saw through

Notifications. You can be told when somebody opens a discussion, when somebody answers one, when you earn a badge, what changed in the week, and when something new appears on the site. Each is a separate tick, and it is off until you turn it on. On an iPhone they work once the site is on your home screen.

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8. Adding a person: what the record will not accept

This is the rule at the top of this guide, as the form enforces it. The record is public and holds people who have died, so a new person has to arrive complete enough to show they are historical. **+ Add Person** on the People page needs:

- First name and surname
- **Year of birth** — four digits; day and month are optional
- **Place of birth**
- **A year of death, if they were born in the last hundred years.** Without one the person may still be living, and the record does not hold the living.
- If a year of death is given, it must come after the year of birth

If something is missing the form lists everything it needs at once and outlines those boxes in red, rather than stopping you one field at a time.

This applies to adding somebody new. **Editing an existing person is not affected** — many people who came in with the census have no birth place, and demanding one would block ordinary corrections. Census imports are not affected either; they are historical records by design.

9. What is built in to help you review a house

Each of these gathers a whole estate's worth of one question in a single request, which is why the pages above can work down a backlog instead of asking house by house.

What it gives you	Where you meet it
Everything the record holds for one house — details, history, description, photographs, residents	Map, clicking a house
The house's census coverage, year by year	Map timeline, and the Census page
Every directory line printed at that house, by volume	Map timeline, and Directories by street
Directory lines for a whole street, set beside the census	Directories by street
Listed-building entries within 40 m of every house at once	Listed buildings
The record's position against the OpenStreetMap outline	Positions vs OpenStreetMap
Map-derived house names and architect colours, unjudged	Dougal's map
Houses holding improbable numbers in one census year	Crowded houses
Unfiled census records grouped by the address they carry	Unfiled records
People who moved from one Park house to another	Who moved
Jobs on this house that somebody could finish tonight	Needs work
Anything anybody has asked about this house	Discussion, or **Ask about this house** on the map
Which houses have been researched and by whom	Dashboard

10. What needs a contributor, and what needs an admin

A contributor can file and move census records, merge duplicate people, edit a person or a house, add residents, add archive items, decide directory, gazette, Wikidata, medal, name and map suggestions, propose notable residents, open, claim and answer research questions, post on the Discussion board, pick up a job from Needs work, and send photographs from the walk.

An admin is needed to import people from a data file, set or export coordinates, delete anything, run the bulk tools that change many records at once, manage users, geocode birthplaces, sort occupations in bulk, and look at the photographs coming in from the walk.

The admin pages. *Activity and alerts* (`/activity`) is every change to the record, who made it and what it was before — and a change can be put back, the undo itself being recorded as a change. *Who is reading it* (`/traffic`) counts visitors, with no cookie and no address stored. *Photos from the walk* (`/photo-review`) is where pictures sent in from the pavement are looked at. *What people have written in*

(`/messages`) is everything sent through the form at `/contact` — anything asking for something to be taken down sorts to the top and stays there until it is settled.

Properties are a special case. The base record of every house lives in `data/all_props.json` in the repository, not in the database, and that file is what the map and the property list are served from. Edits made here on the site are kept separately, in an override store keyed by property id. So a new house, or a correction to a base field, can be made in the repository — while the editing you do on a property page is held alongside it rather than replacing it.

A new house is never added on a hunch. A name from a map, a residents' list, the Land Registry or a directory is a *lead*, not a property. Leads are kept as leads until something places the house.

See what-claude-can-change.md for which of these can be done by an import file and which have to be done on the site.

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11. How fast you can work

The site limits how quickly one account can change things. An ordinary contributor can make a handful of changes in a few seconds and a few hundred in an hour, which is far more than hand editing ever needs and far less than a runaway script. Admins are allowed more, because the bulk tools are theirs. Signing in and out is never counted. If you ever hit it, you are either working faster than a person can, or something is wrong — the Discussion board is the place to say so.

Sign-in is protected by a challenge from Cloudflare, which is why the login box may pause for a moment before it lets you in.

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12. A first hour, if you want somewhere to start

A suggestion, not a rule.

1. Open **Needs work** and read it. Every job on it says what is missing and what would finish it, which is the fastest way to see the shape of what is outstanding.
2. Do a stretch of **Forename sex**. One click covers every person of that name, and it is the fastest way to feel how the record fits together.
3. Try **Duplicate people**. Judging whether two records are one person teaches you more about the sources than anything else on the site.
4. Then **Unfiled records**, which is where the real backlog is — and where one decision can settle a dozen people at once.
5. If it is light outside, open **Walk it** and give it fifteen minutes. A photograph of a house that has none is a real contribution and takes a minute.
6. When you meet something a document cannot answer, **ask on the Discussion board** rather than guessing — and if you know which source would settle it, put it in **Open questions**. A guess entered as fact costs more to undo than it saved.
7. And whatever you are doing, keep *What you can and cannot add* at the top of this guide in mind. It is the one part of it that is not a convention but a rule.

This guide is kept at https://nottinghamparkhouses.com/guide and is rewritten as the site changes, so a printed copy goes out of date. Anything in it that is wrong, or anything on the site that should not be there, can be said at https://nottinghamparkhouses.com/contact